

MIRRA ANDREEVA WINS TITLE AFTER FINAL WIN OVER SHOCK QUALIFIER

In the women's draw, the biggest disruption came from an obscure Polish qualifier, a 500-1 pre-tournament long shot, who streaked all the way to the women's final. Fun to watch but exasperating to play, No. 114-ranked Maja Chwalinska sliced, diced, angled, drop-shotted, lobbed, wrong-footed, moonballed, stealth-volleyed, and otherwise bamboozled three qualifiers, three seeds, a former world No. 3 and an Olympic gold medallist. It took Mirra Andreeva (**right**), a 19-year-old Russian prodigy, to solve this new tennis riddle and end Chwalinska's captivating Cinderella story.

Andreeva, signed by Nike at age 11, was tabbed as a 'can't-miss' future champion when she reached the 2023 Madrid Open fourth round at 16 and the 2024 French Open semifinals at 17.

The Siberian-born and Moscow-trained teenager confirmed her potential during this fortnight, breezing through seven matches for her first Grand Slam title. The 5ft 10in athlete used her superior power, superb strokes and smart tactics to outclass the 5ft 5in Chwalinska 6-3, 6-2 in an anti-climactic final.

"It's been one of my biggest dreams in life, and I'm just super happy that I was able to give my best and win the match and win this tournament," Andreeva said afterwards. "These feelings are something extra special, and now I'm already thinking about how I'm going to prepare for the grass season. I feel like this thing is a little bit addictive, and I really want to do my best to experience all of this for the second time."

Andreeva thus became the youngest French Open champion since all-time great Monica Seles, then 18, in 1992, and the first Russian woman to capture a Grand Slam title since Maria Sharapova here in 2014. For the first time since 1977, no previous Slam champion made the semis in either draw.



Big guns misfire

No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka was rated the favourite heading into Roland Garros. The hard-hitting Belarusian faced her first real test in a fourth-round encounter with 16th-seeded Naomi Osaka, whose four Grand Slam titles also came on hard courts.

As usual, Osaka made a fashion statement par excellence. This time, she ambled onto Court Philippe-Chatrier in an eye-catching golden bomber jacket over a gold sequin playing dress, trailing a tiered train with puffs of tulle. But tournament director Amelie Mauresmo made a far more important statement for equal rights

when this marquee duel ended a notorious streak of 32 straight men's matches in the night session on Court Philippe-Chatrier.

For sustained excellence, the two sluggers produced the match of the tournament. With Osaka leading 5-4 in the opening set, they had already whacked 26 winners, prompting *TNT Sports* analyst Lindsay Davenport to say, "These two are making this slow clay court look like a hard court."

Sabalenka, who leads the WTA stats in every service category, also showcased her stellar volleys, winning 10 of 11 points at the net during the entertaining 7-5, 6-3 victory lasting an hour and 32 minutes. At the end of her on-court